centuries! What is going on? Whether one takes Jehangir's inscription on the Mauryan pillar or the effort to link Akbar to Kalhana's history of Kashmir, the Mughals were trying to build the foundations of their empire in India within the framework of India's civilization. Therefore, they were systematically inserting themselves into civilizational memory. Notwithstanding Feroze Shah Tughlaq's interest in Mauryan pillars, this was a radical shift away from how earlier Delhi Sultans saw themselves.

THE VOYAGES OF ADMIRAL ZHENG HE

While northern India was suffering from waves of invasion from Central Asia, the world of Indian Ocean trade continued to flourish. Both Marco Polo and Ibn Batuta were witness to this. However, under the surface, the role of Indians in the network began to change from the end of the twelfth century. Indian merchants had once been explorers and risk-takers who criss-crossed the oceans in their stitched ships. They could be found in large numbers in ports from the Persian Gulf to China. Buddhist and Brahmin scholars sailed in large numbers to South-East Asia where they were in great demand. Suddenly, a little over a century after the Chola naval raids on Srivijaya, they almost all disappeared. What happened?

The proximate cause for this change was the enforcement of caste rules prohibiting the crossing of the seas. However, the caste rules were merely a reflection of a wider malaise. As I have argued in an earlier book, *The Indian Renaissance*, there appears to have been a shift in India's cultural and civilizational attitude towards innovation and risk-taking. [33] This is not the place to discuss the root causes of this transformation, but there are many independent signs of the closing of the mind. Sanskrit, once an evolving and dynamic language, stopped absorbing new words and usages and eventually fossilized. Sanskrit literature became obsessed with purity of form and became formulaic. Similarly, scientific progress halted as the emphasis shifted from experimentation to learned discourse.

It is interesting that foreigners who visited India at that time noticed the change and wrote about it. Al-Biruni, writing at the same time that Mahmud